modernization programmes.' [23] Krepon's assessment subsequently proved to be accurate. Sha Zukang, China's Ambassador to the Conference on Disarmament and later their Director General for Disarmament matters, implied as much in an oral interview that the Wilson Center recorded with him in 2016. [24] The references in the P-5 statement to the 'root causes' of tension between India and Pakistan in relation to the Kashmir question in particular, was the unkindest cut of all, and China was well aware when it proposed that language that they would be wounding India. The words 'root causes' are used by Pakistan to suggest that the main concern with regard to Kashmir is not terrorism (as India claims) but the unfinished agenda of Partition (as Pakistan claims). Hence, 'root causes', when used in the international context in a UN document, would give Pakistan's narrative on Kashmir a boost. China made sure that this language found its way into UN Security Resolution 1172 of 8 June 1998. [25]

The high point of success for China's strategy to punish India was the Clinton-Jiang Zemin Summit meeting on 27 June 1998. The two leaders issued a stand-alone Joint Statement on South Asia, which was by and in itself not acceptable to India. Matters were made worse by the wording of the document, which suggested that the Americans were giving the Chinese a central role in the maintenance of peace and stability in South Asia. Clinton had already publicly acknowledged such a role for China, during his remarks to the White House Press Corps in the White House Rose Garden on 3 June. [26] India viewed this as an overt manifestation of American alignment with China against India, somewhat akin to Nixon's 1972 tilt to China. It was a low point for the Indo–US relationship. One of its consequences was the absence of any meaningful contact between the embassies of the two countries in Beijing and in the shunning of Indian diplomats at the annual Fourth of July